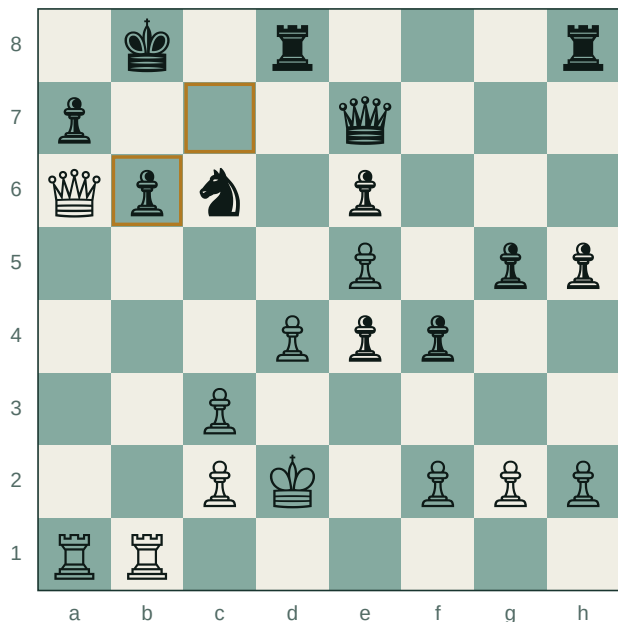


Skewers: White, move 23

Skewers

White to move



Previous move: 22...cxb6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

23. Rxb6+ axb6 24. Qa8+ Kc7 25. Ra7+ Nxa7 26. Qxa7+ Kc6 27. Qxe7

23.Rxb6+ Check restricts Black to 4 legal replies here. From b6 it attacks king on b8 and knight on c6. Recorded reply: **23...axb6**.

24.Qa8+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. From a8 it attacks king on b8 and knight on c6. Recorded reply: **24...Kc7**.

25.Ra7+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. Recorded reply: **25...Nxa7**.

26.Qxa7+ Check restricts Black to 2 legal replies here. The move also takes the knight on a7. Recorded reply: **26...Kc6**.

27.Qxe7 The queen captures the queen on e7.

At the end, nominal material is White 16 / Black 16 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from -3 to +0. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

The defender may block, capture the attacker, or protect the rear piece while moving the front one. Alignment alone is not enough.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A skewer puts the more important target in front. When that target moves, a piece behind it may be lost. Checks make the geometry especially forcing.

HOW TO LOOK

Search ranks, files, and diagonals where two enemy pieces line up. Calculate the first target's legal responses.

The defending king is on b8. Absolute pin: pawn on b6.